adviser to Mullah Mohammad Omar.[35] Given their deep ties to the Taliban and vested interests in the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan, it is not surprising that militants from all of the Deobandi outfits fought against the US counter-attack in the wake of 9/11.

Scattered reports suggest some Lashkar militants may have been involved in battles against the US during the early days of the American invasion, though not necessarily as a Taliban ally. Circumstances surrounding many of the engagements at the time are opaque, but one Pakistani journalist who was covering the war believes skirmishes with US forces occurred as Lashkar fighters were withdrawing from Afghanistan.[36] A high-ranking JuD official told the author there was a division within Lashkar after 9/11 over how to respond, an assessment supported by several local interlocutors following the group at the time.[37] Some in the organization believed the Pakistani government was a puppet of the Americans and that Lashkar should wage a jihad against both. Others continued to prioritize the fight against India, and argued for maintaining a relationship with the state to wage jihad against their common enemy. Ultimately the leadership made the decision not to attack Pakistan or commit cadres to the Afghan theater. However, the JuD official admitted that differences persisted within the organization regarding waging a jihad against America and Pakistan, and that the debate became polarized over time.[38] Further, some members did leave to fight alongside the Taliban, though they did not always break from the group completely and often were welcomed back into the Lashkar-fold. As ensuing chapters will illustrate, the practice of attempting to accommodate those who did not toe the leadership's line may have helped to keep the organization intact, but it also contributed to factionalization within it.

Lashkar's public communications in the wake of 9/11 evinced its inner conflict, though they also likely reflect an organization trying to have it both ways. The group actually issued a statement the day after the 9/11 attacks claiming, 'The attacks on the World Trade Centre and other places were not an act of terrorism but an Islamic duty.'[39] Lashkar backtracked almost immediately and later that day then-Lashkar spokesperson Abdullah Muntazir [the JuD spokesperson for international media at the time this book was written] categorically denied the group ever issued such a statement and refuted any report alleging it had.[40] The next day, Yahya